ZikShare

ACADEMIC VAULT

UNIZIK FRESHER EDITION | 2026

Google Workspace and Cloud Collaboration: Work Together Without Chaos

Shared documents, files and calendars that keep group assignments on track

DIGITAL SKILLS

Digital Skills

General Studies (GST / CED)
GST Directorate | 100L

Written for students, by students.

Practical notes, worked examples, practice questions and a revision plan.

Free to download. No fee, no payment step, no watermark.

Independent study support | Not an official UNIZIK publication

START HERE

Why this pack exists

Group work fails when files are scattered across WhatsApp and nobody knows which version is final. This pack explains shared drives, document permissions, comments and suggestions, version history and offline access, plus a simple group workflow.

This is a student-written study companion, not a reproduced lecture handout or a leaked examination paper. Use it to organise the topics you are taught, practise the kind of thinking your course rewards, and walk into class with better questions.

What you will be able to do

- Structure and share a Google Drive folder with correct permissions.
- Collaborate in Docs and Sheets using comments and suggestions.
- Recover earlier versions and avoid conflicting copies.
- Set up a group workflow with clear ownership and deadlines.

How to use this pack

1. Skim the whole pack once in 20 minutes so you know what is inside.
2. Work through one section at a time with your lecture note and recommended text beside you.
3. Attempt the practice questions before reading the answers. Mark what you missed.
4. Use the final checklist to plan your revision week, one tick per study session.

> **Free to download, always**
> This pack is free. There is no fee, no subscription and no payment step before download, and the full PDF is not watermarked or locked. Share the link with a coursemate instead of forwarding the file.

> **Confirm your official course outline**
> Course codes, credit units and outlines can differ by department and session. Treat this pack as supplementary support and confirm the current outline with your lecturer, course rep or departmental handbook before an assessment.

Organise and share

A predictable folder structure saves more time than any productivity app.

- One master folder per course or project, with subfolders for drafts, sources and final.
- Name files consistently: course, topic, version, date.
- Viewer for readers, commenter for reviewers, editor only for active contributors.
- Share the folder rather than individual files so new files inherit access.
- Use a shared calendar for deadlines and meetings.
- Remove access at the end of the project.

Collaborate without duplicates

Simultaneous editing works when you use the tools designed for it.

- Use comments for feedback and suggestions mode for edits you want reviewed.
- Do not email multiple copies; edit the single shared document.
- Use version history to see who changed what and restore an earlier state.
- Assign sections to specific people with deadlines in the document.
- Turn on offline access for documents you may need without data.
- Keep a final PDF copy for submission so formatting does not shift.

> **Final means final**
> Rename the submitted file 'FINAL' and move it out of the drafts folder. Weeks later, you will know exactly what you submitted.

Data, storage and etiquette

Cloud tools are convenient but not free of limits or risk.

- Free storage is limited; compress large images and clear old videos.
- Do not upload sensitive personal documents to shared folders.
- Check that a link is restricted before posting it publicly.
- Use two-factor authentication on the account.
- Respect bandwidth: avoid large uploads during peak hours on shared networks.
- Back up critical files locally or in a second service.

Cloud tools are for working together

A shared cloud document changes collaboration from sending versions by email to editing one file together. That eliminates "final_v3_edited" confusion, but it introduces new problems: accidental deletion, unclear ownership, and edits nobody can trace.

The fix is conventions. Name files consistently (course-date-topic), keep one folder per course, and agree who owns which document. Use comments for discussion and the document itself for content, so that the final text is not buried under debate.

Version history is the safety net. Learn where it is and how to restore a previous version before you need it. It is the single most useful feature in any cloud document and almost nobody uses it until something is lost.

The tools and their real uses

Docs for writing, Sheets for data and calculation, Slides for presentation, Forms for surveys and quizzes, Drive for storage and sharing, and Calendar for scheduling. Each has a mobile app, but long documents and spreadsheets are far easier on a laptop.

Sharing permissions have three levels that matter: viewer (read), commenter (suggest but not change), and editor (change). Give the lowest level that works. Sharing a folder with "anyone with the link" is how private material becomes public.

Offline access is worth configuring in advance. Download the files you need before travelling, and check that they open without a connection. Cloud tools are excellent until the data runs out.

> **Link, do not attach**
> Send the link with the right permission rather than an attachment. Attachments multiply versions; links keep everyone on one file.

Group work without group chaos

Divide by section, not by sentence. Each person owns a section and is responsible for its content and citations; one person owns the final edit and the formatting. Agree the deadline for drafts as a date and time, not "before submission".

Use suggestion mode for edits to other people's sections, and comments for disagreements. This preserves the author's control and leaves a record of what changed and why - which is also useful if a lecturer asks who wrote what.

Track tasks somewhere visible: a shared checklist, a simple sheet, or a task list in the document. Group work fails silently when everyone assumes someone else is doing the referencing.

WORKED EXAMPLES

Do it once, slowly

These are not model answers to copy. They show the reasoning a strong student would use, step by step, so you can repeat the process on a question you have not seen.

1. Setting up a group assignment

Five students, one 2,500-word report, three weeks.

1. Create one folder and one master document.
2. Agree the structure and assign one section per person.
3. Set draft deadline, review deadline and final deadline as dates and times.
4. Give editing rights to all, but assign one final editor.
5. Agree the citation style and who checks the reference list.
6. Use comments for feedback and version history if something is lost.

> **What to carry forward**
> One file, one owner per section, one final editor, deadlines with times.

2. Recovering deleted work

A group member deleted two pages of the report.

1. Open File, then Version history.
2. Identify the version before the deletion by timestamp.
3. Restore or copy the missing section into the current version.
4. Restrict editing rights for that member to commenter if it was careless.
5. Ask everyone to work in suggestion mode from then on.
6. Take a PDF snapshot at each milestone.

> **What to carry forward**
> Version history first, blame later. Then change permissions, not friendships.

EXAM TECHNIQUE

Questions with model answers

Written in the shape your course is usually examined, with the marking logic spelled out. Attempt each one under time before you read the outline.

Q1. Explain the three main sharing permission levels and when each is appropriate.

10 marks

1. Viewer for finished documents.
2. Commenter for review without alteration.
3. Editor for co-authoring.
4. Principle of least privilege.

Q2. Describe conventions that prevent version chaos in group work.

10 marks

1. One master document with a link.
2. Consistent file naming and one folder.
3. Section ownership and named final editor.
4. Deadlines with dates and times.

REFERENCE

Glossary

Use these definitions in your own sentences; a copied definition rarely earns full marks.

Cloud storage. Files stored on remote servers and accessed over the internet.

Version history. A record of changes allowing restoration of earlier versions.

Suggestion mode. An editing mode that proposes changes rather than applying them.

Permission level. The rights granted to a user: view, comment or edit.

Shared drive. A folder whose contents belong to a group rather than an individual.

Offline access. The ability to open and edit files without a connection.

Sync. Keeping local and remote copies of files consistent.

Milestone. A fixed point in a project with a defined deliverable.

Master document. The single authoritative file for a piece of work.

Two-factor authentication. A second verification step beyond a password.

Your four-week plan

Week 1 - Organise

Structure.

- Create one folder per course.
- Adopt a file naming convention.
- Set up two-factor authentication.

Week 2 - Collaborate

Permissions.

- Share a document at each permission level.
- Use comments and suggestion mode.
- Practise restoring a version.

Week 3 - Data

Sheets and Forms.

- Build a shared tracker.
- Create a short survey form.
- Analyse the responses in a sheet.

Week 4 - Group work

Delivery.

- Run one assignment with the conventions.
- Hold a five-minute stand-up.
- Take a PDF snapshot at submission.

Where to read more

Entry-level texts you can find in the university library or a departmental reading list. Confirm editions with your lecturer.

- The help documentation for your cloud provider's document tools.
- A guide to collaborative writing practice.
- Your institution's data protection guidance for student work.

PRACTICE, NOT PREDICTION

Check your understanding

These questions are written for this pack to test the ideas above. They are not past examination questions and do not predict what your lecturer will set. Answer first, then compare.

1. What permission should reviewers have?

Answer: Commenter access, so they can give feedback without altering the document text.

2. Why share a folder instead of separate files?

Answer: New files inherit the folder's permissions, reducing missing-access problems.

3. How do you recover a deleted section in Google Docs?

Answer: Use File then Version history to view and restore an earlier version.

4. Why create a PDF before submission?

Answer: A PDF fixes the layout so formatting does not change on another device.

5. Give two cloud-storage safety practices.

Answer: Restrict link sharing and enable two-factor authentication on the account.

Your 7-step action plan

Tick each step only when you have done it. A tick you cannot defend is worse than an empty box.

- [ ] Create a course folder structure with three subfolders.
- [ ] Set correct permissions for one shared document.
- [ ] Practise commenting and suggesting changes.
- [ ] Restore an earlier version in a test document.
- [ ] Enable offline access for one folder.
- [ ] Set up a shared calendar for group deadlines.
- [ ] Export a final PDF and check formatting.

Keep going

One pack will not carry a semester. Pair this with your lecture notes, tutorials, and the past questions your department actually releases. If a topic still feels unclear, take a specific question to your lecturer or course rep - "I do not understand the difference between X and Y" gets a better answer than "I do not understand this course".

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YOUR WORKSPACE

Notes, questions and things to ask

Use this page in class or during revision. Write questions you could not answer instead of copying slides.

Three ideas I can now explain without notes:

A question I still cannot answer:

For my lecturer or course rep:

Next revision action and date:

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